

Production Server Real Scenario based Interview Questions

Acknowledge → Assess Impact → Investigate → Fix/Workaround → Escalate → Prevent

? *Production server is down. What will you do?*

What they expect:

- Incident management mindset
- Calm, structured approach

Ideal flow (say this):

1. Acknowledge incident (P1)
2. Check monitoring alerts
3. Login via console / DR access
4. Identify issue (CPU, disk, memory, network)
5. Restore service ASAP (restart, failover)
6. Communicate updates
7. Root RCA after resolution

? *Root filesystem is 100% full. What will you do?*

Sample Answer:

First, I will check the impact and confirm which filesystem is full using `df -h`.

Then I'll identify which directory is consuming space using `du -sh /*`.

Usually `/var/log`, application logs, or temp files cause this.

I will safely clean logs or rotate them — **without deleting critical data**.

If space is still required, I'll check for deleted-but-open files using `lsof`.

If this is production, I'll inform stakeholders and escalate if permanent fix like disk extension is required.

Finally, I'll document the RCA and preventive action.

? Disk shows free space but cannot create files. Why?

Sample Answer:

This usually indicates inode exhaustion.

I'll check inode usage using `df -i`.

Then I'll identify directories with many small files and clean or archive them.

This often happens due to application logs or temp files.

After cleanup, I'll monitor inode usage and update SOP to prevent recurrence.

? Load average high but CPU idle — why?

Sample Answer:

This usually indicates I/O wait or blocked processes.

I'll check disk I/O and filesystem health.

Applications waiting on disk or network can increase load without CPU usage.

? Application is slow but server is up. How do you troubleshoot?

Expected areas:

- CPU (`top` , `htop`)
- Memory (`free -m`)
- Disk IO (`iostat` , `df -h`)
- Network latency

- App logs

? User requests sudo access in production – how will you handle?

Correct approach:

- It is a **Service Request**
- Validate approval
- Follow **least privilege**
- Time-bound access
- Audit & rollback

? Disk full alert on production server – what will you do immediately?

Key steps:

1. Confirm alert
2. Identify filesystem (`df -h`)
3. Find large files (`du -sh`)
4. Clear logs / temp
5. Extend disk (if needed)
6. Permanent fix + RCA

? You need to upgrade kernel in production. How will you proceed?

Must mention:

- Change Request (CR)
- Impact analysis
- Maintenance window
- Rollback plan

- Stakeholder communication
- Post-change validation

? *Emergency fix needed in prod. No time for approvals.*

Answer:

- Emergency Change
- Minimal fix
- Inform stakeholders
- Document after fix

? *CPU usage is 95% continuously. What will you do?*

Expected steps:

- Identify process
- Check load average
- Decide kill / renice / scale
- Root cause analysis

? *Same incident is happening repeatedly. What will you do?*

Correct ITIL thinking:

- Create Problem ticket
- Perform RCA
- Permanent fix
- Prevent recurrence

? *How do you write an RCA?*

Mention:

- What happened
- When it happened
- Impact
- Root cause
- Corrective & preventive actions

? *How do you communicate during a P1 outage?*

Answer should include:

- Frequent updates
- Clear, non-technical language
- ETA if possible
- Single point of contact

? *Stakeholder is pressuring you to fix faster.*

They expect:

- Calm handling
- Set realistic expectations
- Focus on restoration first

? *Developer wants direct prod access. What will you do?*

Correct answer:

- Check approval
- Read-only or limited access
- Time-bound
- Audit logging

? Someone made unauthorized change in production.

Say this:

- Incident + Security review
- Audit logs
- Revert change
- Preventive controls

? Production data deleted accidentally. What will you do?

Expected:

- Stop further writes
- Restore from backup
- Validate data
- RCA & prevention

? Deleted file but disk space not freed?

Sample Answer:

This happens when a process is still holding the file.

I'll use `ls -l | grep deleted` to identify the process.

I'll restart the service safely during a maintenance window or after approval.

This frees disk space without data corruption.

? Permissions look correct but access is denied. Why?

Sample Answer:

I'll first verify directory permissions because execute permission is mandatory to access files inside directories.

Then I'll check **SELinux status**, as it can block access even when permissions are correct.

If needed, I'll review audit logs and fix context using `restorecon`.

I'll never disable SELinux in production without approval.

? Difference between file and directory permissions?

Sample Answer:

For files, read means view content and execute means run the file.

For directories, read means list files, write means create/delete files, and execute means access the directory.

Missing execute permission on a directory causes "permission denied" even if file permissions are correct.

? What is a zombie process?

Sample Answer:

A zombie process has completed execution but its parent has not collected its exit status.

It doesn't consume CPU but indicates improper process handling.

Restarting the parent process usually clears zombies.

? Service not starting after reboot. What will you do?

Sample Answer:

I'll first check service status using `systemctl status`.

Then I'll review logs using `journalctl -u service-name`.

If it's a configuration issue, I'll fix and reload daemon.

If required, I'll restart the service and monitor.

I'll document the fix and update SOP.

? Difference between start and enable?

Sample Answer:

start runs the service immediately.

`enable` ensures the service starts automatically after reboot.

In production, both are required for persistent availability.

? Ping works but SSH doesn't. Why?

Sample Answer:

This indicates network connectivity is fine.

I'll check whether SSH service is running, firewall rules, port configuration, and SELinux.

I'll also confirm SSH port and access rules before restarting the service.

? How do you troubleshoot SSH not accessible?

Sample Answer:

I'll check service status, listening port, firewall rules, SELinux, and authentication logs.

I avoid restarting SSH blindly on production systems to prevent lockout.

? What will you do during a P1 incident?

Sample Answer:

First, I acknowledge the incident and assess impact.

I check monitoring dashboards and logs to identify root cause.

I apply a safe workaround to restore service quickly.

I communicate regular updates to stakeholders.

After resolution, I document RCA and preventive measures.

? How do you handle pressure in production?

Sample Answer:

- I stay calm, follow SOPs, and prioritize tasks based on impact.
- I avoid assumptions and focus on facts and logs.
- If needed, I escalate early to avoid delays.

? Incident vs Service Request?

Sample Answer:

- Incident is an unplanned interruption affecting service.
- Service request is a user-initiated request like access or installation.
- Handling differs based on SLA and priority.

? What details do you add while updating a ticket?

Sample Answer:

- I add issue description, steps taken, findings, resolution, timestamps, and next action.
- Clear documentation helps faster resolution and audits.

? How do you deploy safely in production?

Sample Answer:

- I follow change management process.
- I take backups, verify prerequisites, deploy during approved window, validate post-deployment, and keep rollback ready.
- No direct changes without approval.

? How do you handle an angry customer?

Sample Answer:

I listen calmly, acknowledge the issue, avoid technical jargon, and provide realistic updates.

I never commit without confirmation and keep communication transparent.

FINAL INTERVIEW TIP (VERY IMPORTANT)

Always use phrases like:

- "In production environment..."
- "Based on impact and SLA..."
- "Following SOP and change process..."
- "After RCA, preventive steps..."

HOW TO IMPRESS A 12+ YEAR OPS MANAGER

Use these keywords naturally:

- **Production safety**
- **Root cause analysis**
- **Impact assessment**
- **Escalation**
- **Documentation**
- **Customer communication**
- **SOP / Change process**

QUESTIONS THEY MAY ASK YOU DIRECTLY

Be ready for:

- Why operations role?
- Are you comfortable with 24/7 support?
- How do you handle pressure?
- Example of critical issue you handled
- How do you prioritize tasks?
- What will you do if senior engineer is unavailable?